

RENAISSANCE

Assessment Question: How has medicine changed from c1250 to the modern day?

Name: _____

Class: _____

Progress & Assessment Tracker	Effort	Level	Teacher Comments	
L1: KT2.1: Did the Renaissance change beliefs about the causes of illness?				
L2: KT2.2: Did treatments improve during the Renaissance?				
L3: KT2.3: How significant were William Harvey and the Great Plague?				
Final Unit Grade:				



Section B: Thematic Study (Medicine in Britain)

This section tests your understanding of change, continuity, and causation across 800 years of British medicine.

Question 3: Explain One Similarity or Difference...

4
Marks

5
mins

5:00

TARGET OBJECTIVE

AO2 (Analyse similarity and difference across historical periods)

THE SYMMETRICAL SPLICING METHOD

[Comparative Thesis]

[Era 1: Context]

[Era 2: Matching Context]

Examiner Red Flags

The "Two-Story" Essay:

Writing a block of facts about the first era, followed by a

Grade 9 Checklist

Immediate Comparison:

Does my very first sentence make a direct comparison

separate block about the second era without linking them is capped at 2 marks.

Concept Slippage: If the question asks about prevention, do not write about treatment.

Chronological Blunders: Placing key developments in the wrong century.

using a comparative connective?

Symmetrical Alignment: Do the details I provide for Era 2 directly match the theme of Era 1?

Single-Paragraph Splicing: Is my answer written as a single, cohesive paragraph?

Question 4: Explain Why... (Causation)

12
Marks

15-18
mins

18:00

TARGET OBJECTIVE

AO2 (Analyse causation) and AO1 (Demonstrate precise knowledge)

THE THREE-CAUSAL-PILLARS LAYOUT

No Introduction

Para 1

Stimulus A

Para 2

Stimulus B

Para 3

Own Knowledge

Examiner Red Flags

The Stimulus Cap: Failing to introduce an independent third factor from your own knowledge caps your mark at 8/12.

The Narrative Biography

Trap: Writing a chronological story instead of explaining *why* their work led to rapid progress.

Grade 9 Checklist

The Rule of Three: Have I structured my answer into exactly three separate paragraphs?

Causal Topic Openers: Does the first sentence of each paragraph state a clear, analytical cause?

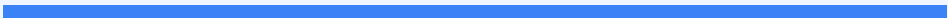
Double Causal Connectives: Have I used the Edexcel Connective Chain ("Consequently...", "This meant that...") at least twice per paragraph?

Question 5 & 6: Evaluative Essay

16+4
Marks

25-30
mins

30:00



TARGET OBJECTIVE

AO2 (Evaluate significance/change) and AO1 (Wide-ranging knowledge)

THE GRADE 9 JUDGMENT ARC

1

Intro

(Thesis & Criteria)

2

FOR

(Given Factor)

3

AGAINST

(Own Knowledge)

4

Conclusion

(Apply Criteria)

Examiner Red Flags

The One-Sided Argument:

Failing to analyze alternative factors traps your essay at Level 2 (8 marks).

"Fencing" Conclusions:

Reaching a conclusion that simply states both sides were equally important.

Concept Slippage: Treating "care" and "treatment" as identical.

Grade 9 Checklist

Explicit Evaluation Criteria:

Have I defined the historical criteria I will use to measure the statement?

The Argument AGAINST:

Have I evaluated alternative factors using my own knowledge?

Substantiated Verdict: Have I explicitly applied the criteria established in my intro to justify which factor was most significant?

SPaG: Have I capitalized proper nouns and correctly spelled specialist terms?

L1: KT2.1: Did the Renaissance change beliefs about the causes of illness?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain how Thomas Sydenham's scientific approach to observation changed the diagnosis of disease.
- ☐ Assess the role of the printing press and the Royal Society in communicating and spreading scientific ideas.

The Medical Renaissance was an exciting era of intellectual shift. As the Church's influence slowly declined, a new 'scientific approach' emerged that encouraged questioning traditional authority. While ordinary people still clung to old superstitions and the Four Humours, brilliant individuals and new technologies began to challenge ancient medical ideas, laying the vital foundations for modern medicine.

Did you know?

- 1676: The year Thomas Sydenham published his groundbreaking textbook *Observationes Medicae*, revolutionizing medical diagnosis.
- c.1440: The approximate year Johannes Gutenberg invented the printing press, allowing medical ideas to spread without Church censorship.
- 1665: The year the Royal Society first published *Philosophical Transactions*, the world's first scientific journal for sharing discoveries.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 6

1. In what year did the Black Death arrive in England?

2. What did medieval people believe caused the Black Death?

3. State one method used to try to prevent the Black Death.

4. Why did the Black Death cause such a high death toll?

5. To what extent did the Black Death change medical ideas?

6. Recall: Who was Claudius Galen and what was their key contribution to medicine?

Vocabulary Check

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

Humanism Nullius in Verba Animalcules
--

During the Medical Renaissance, a cultural shift known as _____ encouraged doctors and scientists to think for themselves, question ancient texts, and verify claims through empirical observation. This hands-on mindset was championed by the Royal Society, whose strict motto _____ drove researchers to reject traditional theories in favor of rigorous experimentation. Although new scientific instruments like advanced microscopes allowed pioneers to observe microscopic _____ for the very first time, these discoveries had little immediate impact on treating patients because there was no proof that these tiny organisms actually caused illness.

Q1. Identify one invention that helped spread new ideas during the Renaissance.

Q2. Describe what Vesalius discovered about Galen.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q3)

How did Sydenham's belief that diseases were like plants or animals challenge the traditional Theory of the Four Humours?

- ☐ A. It proved that diseases were caused by invisible germs.
 - ☐ B. It meant diseases were separate entities with specific symptoms, rather than a personal imbalance of a patient's humours.
 - ☐ C. It showed that diseases could only be cured by herbal remedies.
 - ☐ D. It proved that diseases were a punishment from God.
-

Q4. Explain the purpose of the Royal Society.

Q5. Evaluate the extent to which the Renaissance changed beliefs about the causes of illness.

Pair & Share Activity

Prompt: In the period c1500–c1700, was the work of individual physicians like Thomas Sydenham more important in challenging traditional medical beliefs than institutional developments like the founding of the Royal Society?

*Think: Jot down your choice and one piece of evidence from the sources (e.g., Sydenham's *Observationes Medicae* classifying diseases like scarlet fever vs. the Royal Society publishing Leeuwenhoek's discoveries in *Philosophical Transactions*).*

Your Notes:

Historian's Corner: The Debate over the Pace of Change in Renaissance Medicine

Historians often debate the extent to which the Renaissance c1500–c1700 represented a genuine breakthrough or a period of stagnation in the understanding of disease causes. Traditional historians emphasize a 'Scientific Revolution,' pointing to the works of Vesalius, Harvey, and Leeuwenhoek as a rapid and complete dismantling of medieval Galenism. However, revisionist historians argue that this period was actually characterized by overwhelming continuity for the average patient. They argue that while elite physicians in organizations like the Royal Society debated new ideas, daily treatments (such as bleeding and purging to balance the humours) remained completely unchanged. Because there was no scientific proof that Leeuwenhoek's 'animalcules' actually caused disease, everyday medical practice clung tightly to the Theory of the Four Humours and miasma for centuries after the Renaissance.

GCSE Exam Practice

Q6. Explain why there were changes in the way ideas about the causes of disease and illness were communicated in the period c1500–c1700. (12 marks)

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Q Explain why there was rapid progress in anatomical knowledge in the Renaissance period (c1500â€”c1700). (12 marks)

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Q Explain one way in which knowledge of human anatomy in the Renaissance period (c1500–c1700) was different from knowledge of human anatomy in the medieval period (c1250–c1500). (4 marks)

1. Explain why there were changes in the way ideas about the causes of disease and illness were communicated in the period c1500â€"c1700. (12 marks)

- The printing press
- The Royal Society

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General Notes

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☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

L2: KT2.2: Did treatments improve during the Renaissance?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Analyze the continuities and changes in Renaissance treatments and preventions, including the impact of exploration and alchemy.
- ☐ Explain how institutional changes, specifically the Dissolution of the Monasteries, altered hospital care in England.

The Medical Renaissance saw an explosion of scientific curiosity, yet this rarely translated into better everyday medical care. While pioneer anatomists fundamentally transformed medical training by proving ancient authorities wrong, the average patient still relied on traditional herbal remedies, bleeding, and local wise women. The unexpected closure of monastery hospitals forced a massive rethink in healthcare, slowly paving the way for specialised hospitals focused on actually curing the sick.

Did you know?

- 1536: The year King Henry VIII initiated the Dissolution of the Monasteries, forcing the vast majority of English hospitals to close.
- 1543: The exact year Andreas Vesalius published his revolutionary, highly accurate anatomy textbook, *On the Fabric of the Human Body*.
- 300: The approximate number of anatomical mistakes Vesalius proved Galen had made because the Roman physician had dissected animals instead of humans.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 5

1. What was the Renaissance?

2. What invention helped spread new medical ideas during the Renaissance?

3. Who was Thomas Sydenham?

4. Why did the influence of the Church begin to decline in the Renaissance?

5. Explain why the Theory of the Four Humours was still used despite new discoveries.

Vocabulary Check

Write a historically accurate sentence connecting two terms from the glossary box below.

Transference Iatrochemistry Dissolution of the Monasteries
--

Your Sentence:

Q1. Identify one new herbal remedy brought from the 'New World'.

Q2. Describe the approach of Thomas Sydenham.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q3)

Why was the importation of cinchona bark from South America a more successful treatment than traditional humoral methods?

- ☐ A. It contained quinine, which actually treated the specific symptoms of malaria, rather than just attempting to rebalance humours.
- ☐ B. It was a holy relic blessed by the Pope.
- ☐ C. It killed the germs that caused malaria.
- ☐ D. It was used to draw bad humours out of the skin.

Q4. Explain why treatments for ordinary people hardly changed during the Renaissance.

Q5. To what extent did the 'New World' improve medical treatments?

Pair & Share Activity

Prompt: In the period c1500â€”c1700, did the introduction of global herbal remedies and chemical cures represent a more significant improvement in treatment than the gradual reforms made to the training of physicians?

Think: Jot down your choice and one piece of evidence from the sources (such as the successful use of cinchona bark for malaria versus the fact that physicians' training was still largely book-based with very little hands-on dissection experience).

Your Notes:

Historian's Corner: The Debate over Renaissance Progress: Breakthrough or Backstep?

Historians actively debate whether the Renaissance represented genuine progress in patient care or a period of regression. Traditionalist accounts often celebrated the 'rebirth' of medical science, highlighting how the shift towards chemical cures and Vesalian anatomy laid the foundations of modern clinical practice. However, revisionist social historians argue that for the average sick person, the Renaissance was actually a time of decline in care. They point out that Henry VIII's closure of the monasteries in 1536 destroyed the medieval hospital safety net, leaving thousands of poor patients without any institutional care. Furthermore, they highlight that some new treatments, such as using highly toxic mercury to treat syphilis or smoking tobacco as a 'cure-all' defense against plague, actually did far more physical harm than medieval herbal remedies ever did.

GCSE Exam Practice

Q6. Explain why there was rapid progress in anatomical knowledge in the Renaissance period (c1500â€"c1700). (12 marks)

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Q Explain why there was little change in medical treatments during the Renaissance period (c1500â€"c1700), despite new anatomical discoveries. (12 marks)

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Q Explain one way in which medical treatments in the Renaissance period (c1500â€"c1700) were similar to medical treatments in the medieval period (c1250â€"c1500). (4 marks)

1. Explain why there was rapid progress in anatomical knowledge in the Renaissance period (c1500–c1700). (12 marks)

- Andreas Vesalius
- The printing press

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General Notes

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☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

L3: KT2.3: How significant were William Harvey and the Great Plague?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain the significance of William Harvey's discovery and the reasons for its limited short-term impact.
- ☐ Compare the government and public responses to the 1665 Great Plague with the 1348 Black Death.

By the 17th century, medical knowledge was advancing, but practical treatment lagged far behind. William Harvey's brilliant discovery of blood circulation proved ancient theories wrong and laid the foundations for modern physiology, though it saved no lives at the time. Meanwhile, the devastating Great Plague of 1665 demonstrated that without an understanding of germs, even organized government action was powerless to stop a catastrophic epidemic.

Did you know?

- 1628: The year William Harvey published his groundbreaking book proving the circulation of the blood.
- 100,000: The approximate number of Londoners who died during the Great Plague of 1665 (one-fifth of the city's population).
- 28: The number of days an infected family was locked inside their house under the strict new quarantine rules.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 6

1. Who wrote 'On the Fabric of the Human Body' (1543)?

2. What did Vesalius prove about Galen's anatomical ideas?

3. What was 'transference'?

4. Explain how hospitals changed during the Renaissance.

5. Why did Vesalius' discoveries have limited immediate impact on everyday medical treatment?

6. Recall: Who was Andreas Vesalius and what was their key contribution to medicine?

Vocabulary Check

Write a clear definition and a historically accurate sentence for the term: **Circulation**

Q1. Identify what William Harvey proved about the blood.

Q2. Describe how Harvey proved Galen wrong.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q3)

What was the main reason why Harvey's discovery of blood circulation did not immediately change medical treatments?

- ☐ A. Because he refused to publish his findings in a book.
- ☐ B. Because the Church banned his book and executed him.
- ☐ C. Because knowing how the blood circulated did not provide doctors with any new drugs or cures for sick patients.
- ☐ D. Because he still believed the liver manufactured blood.

Q4. Explain how the Great Plague of 1665 was dealt with differently from the Black Death.

Q5. Evaluate the short-term significance of Harvey's discovery.

Pair & Share Activity

Prompt: Why was William Harvey's brilliant discovery of blood circulation completely ignored in the prevention and treatment of the Great Plague of 1665?

Think: Jot down your explanation and one piece of evidence (e.g., how knowing that blood flows did not help cure a disease when germs were still undiscovered, or how doctors did not believe Harvey because they felt it had no practical clinical application).

Your Notes:

Historian's Corner: The Debate over the Significance of William Harvey

Historians often debate whether William Harvey represents a sudden turning point or a very gradual stepping stone in medicine. Traditionalist historians celebrate his work as a revolutionary breakthrough that demolished Galenic physiology. However, revisionist historians emphasize the extreme limits of his immediate significance. They point out that a lot of contemporary doctors simply ignored or openly criticized Harvey because his discovery offered no practical treatment for sick patients. As a result, English medical textbooks continued to print Galen's flawed theories until 1651, and Harvey's findings were not taught in universities until 1673, decades after his discovery.

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Q Explain one way in which the response to the Great Plague in London (1665) was different from the response to the Black Death (1348). (4 marks)

1. ~The most effective method of preventing the spread of the Great Plague (1665) was the use of quarantine.™ How far do you agree? Explain your answer. (16 marks + 4 marks for SPaG) (16 marks)

You may use the following in your answer:

- Watchmen
- The animal cull

You must also use information of your own.

General Notes

[illegible]

- ☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

Factors Overview: Renaissance

Edexcel focuses heavily on the factors that drove medical progress (or held it back). For each factor below, write one specific historical example from this period that either helped or hindered medical progress.

Factor	Specific Historical Example & Impact
Individuals	
The Church & Religion	
Government & Wealth	
Science & Technology	
Attitudes in Society	
War	

Factor	Specific Historical Example & Impact